BEGINNER'S GUIDE TO

PORTABLE OPERATIONS

A simple, practical starting point for taking amateur radio beyond the shack. Learn the basics, find an Elmer, connect with a local club, build a dependable portable station, and make your first contacts from the great outdoors.

GET OUTSIDE. GET ON THE AIR. • KENTUCKY • OUTDOORS • RADIO

Use our tools, then check for yourself. KPC builds these maps, guides and tools to help you plan, but we're volunteers working from public data, and we make mistakes. Boundaries change, maps don't always line up, and some land inside a park line is private. Before you activate, check the official agency map, confirm the land is public and open, and follow the rules of each program you're activating. You're responsible for making sure your activation is valid. Spot something wrong? **Let us know** so we can fix it.

Welcome to Portable Radio

Portable operation is simply amateur radio away from your normal home station. It can be as simple as a handheld at a picnic table, a small HF radio and wire antenna at a campsite, or a complete field station with batteries, multiple antennas and logging equipment.

The important part is not how expensive or complicated the station is. Portable radio is about learning to set up, operate, adapt to the conditions, and enjoy the experience.

THE KPC APPROACH

Start small. Learn from other operators. Build a station you understand. Then go farther.

What Can You Do Portable?

POTA	Parks on the Air — travel to a qualifying park and operate from it.
Field Day	Join other operators for a large temporary station and learn by doing.
Camping	Take the radio along on a weekend trip and operate whenever you have time.
VHF/UHF	Use a handheld or mobile-style setup for local contacts, repeaters and simplex.
HF	Use the HF bands for regional, national and international contacts.
Just Get Outside	A picnic table, a battery and a simple antenna can be enough.

Don't Go It Alone

One of the best ways to get comfortable with portable operations is to spend time with another operator. In amateur radio, that person is often called an **Elmer** — an experienced ham who is willing to teach, demonstrate and answer questions.

01

Find an Elmer

Ask at a local club meeting, net, hamfest or operating event. Look for someone who enjoys portable radio, POTA, antennas or field operations. You do not need someone who knows everything — you need someone willing to help.

02

Join a Local Club

A good club can shorten the learning curve dramatically. Clubs provide people to talk to, operating events, equipment advice, licensing help, repeaters, Field Day opportunities and often members willing to mentor newcomers.

03

Go Along on an Activation

Before buying a pile of gear, watch an experienced operator set up. See how the antenna goes up, how the radio is powered, how contacts are logged and what gets packed back into the vehicle.

04

Ask Questions

Ask why they selected a particular antenna, battery, radio or logging method. Portable radio is full of trade-offs, and seeing those choices in the field is often more useful than watching another equipment review.

KPC TIP

Your first portable station does not have to be your final station. Learn what you actually enjoy before spending money on upgrades.

Build a Simple Portable Station

A dependable portable station is a system. Radio, antenna, feed line, power, logging and the small items that keep the station running all have to work together.

PART	GOOD BEGINNER CHOICE
Radio	A VHF/UHF handheld for local work, or an HF transceiver if you want HF/POTA.
Antenna	For HF: an end-fed half-wave (EFHW) or simple dipole is a strong starting point. For VHF/UHF: a good portable vertical or roll-up antenna.
Support	Telescoping mast, fiberglass pole, tripod, or another safe support. Follow park rules and never damage trees.
Feed line	A length appropriate for the station; keep it organized and protected from foot traffic.
Power	A properly sized rechargeable battery/power station. Carry enough capacity for your planned operating time.
Logging	Phone/tablet logging app, laptop, or paper log as a backup.
Safety	Headlamp, first-aid basics, weather awareness, high-visibility guy lines/tape, water and a way to navigate if GPS fails.

The Antenna Matters

For HF portable work, a simple wire antenna deployed efficiently can outperform a more expensive antenna installed poorly. An EFHW is popular because one wire and a matching transformer can cover multiple bands when designed for that purpose. A resonant dipole is another excellent option. A portable vertical can be very convenient when space or supports are limited.

> **BEGINNER RULE**
>
> Prioritize a good antenna location and safe deployment before buying more radio power. A well-deployed antenna is often the best first upgrade.

Setting Up Your Antenna

Portable antennas are often a compromise between ideal performance and practical deployment. The goal is a station that is safe, repeatable and easy to put up.

1. PICK THE OPERATING LOCATION

Look for an open area with room for your antenna, feed line and operating position. Keep clear of power lines, roads, trails and places where people may walk.

2. GET THE WIRE UP

An EFHW or dipole can be supported from a telescoping mast or other approved support. A sloping or inverted-V arrangement is often easier than trying to make a perfect horizontal installation.

3. KEEP PEOPLE SAFE

Mark guy lines and feed lines so they are visible. Do not create trip hazards. Do not climb trees or attach antennas to park trees unless the park specifically allows it.

4. CHECK THE RADIO

Before calling CQ, verify the correct band, mode, frequency, power level, time and logging setup. If your radio has an SWR display or you have an external meter, use it to confirm the antenna system is behaving as expected.

5. LISTEN FIRST

Listen long enough to understand what is happening on the frequency. Make sure the frequency is clear before transmitting and follow normal amateur-radio operating practices.

PARK ETIQUETTE

Check the park's rules before deploying. Be respectful of other visitors, obey quiet hours, and ask park staff when your setup is unusual, large or likely to attract attention.

Your First POTA Activation

Parks on the Air is one of the easiest ways to turn portable radio into an adventure. You choose a qualifying park, take your station with you, make contacts, and submit your log. POTA itself is not a contest; it is an operating program built around portable contacts.

START WITH AN EASY PARK

Choose a place that is easy to reach and already familiar to you. POTA recommends selecting parks and station styles that match your experience level. For your first activation, avoid turning the trip into an expedition.

KNOW THE CURRENT POTA REQUIREMENT

Under the current POTA rules, a successful activation requires at least **10 valid QSOs from the park within one UTC day**. You can still submit an unsuccessful activation so hunters can receive credit for valid contacts.

A SIMPLE FIRST-ACTIVATION FLOW

1. Create/check your POTA account.
2. Confirm the park reference and current access rules.
3. Charge the radio and battery.
4. Pack the antenna, support, feed line and logging backup.
5. Arrive, find a safe operating location and deploy the station.
6. Confirm the correct time and start logging.
7. Listen, choose a clear frequency and call CQ.
8. If possible, spot your activation so hunters can find you.
9. Keep the exchanges short when the pileup gets busy.
10. Before leaving, save your log, tear down completely and leave no trace.

> **REMEMBER**
>
> POTA has no recommended frequency. Use a legal frequency within your license privileges, listen before transmitting, and follow normal band plans and operating etiquette.

The Beginner's Packing List

Print this page, save it to your phone, and build your own checklist as you learn what you actually use.

RADIO	☐ Radio ☐ Microphone/key ☐ Headphones/earbuds ☐ Manual
ANTENNA	☐ Antenna ☐ Matching unit ☐ Feed line ☐ Mast/support ☐ Guy lines ☐ Stakes
POWER	☐ Charged battery ☐ Power cable ☐ Spare/fuse if appropriate ☐ Battery indicator
LOGGING	☐ Logging app/device ☐ Correct time/UTC ☐ Paper + pencil backup
SAFETY	☐ Water ☐ Weather plan ☐ Headlamp ☐ First-aid basics ☐ High-vis tape
NAVIGATION	☐ Park map ☐ Phone/GPS ☐ Backup navigation method
COMFORT	☐ Chair ☐ Table ☐ Shade/rain cover ☐ Food/snack ☐ Bug protection
PARK	☐ Access checked ☐ Operating rules checked ☐ Quiet hours checked ☐ Leave-no-trace plan

The Best First Purchase May Be Experience

Before buying a bigger radio, a larger battery or a complicated antenna system, go portable with someone who already does it. You will quickly learn what matters to you: operating time, weight, setup speed, bands, modes, camping comfort, or simply making contacts from beautiful places.

KPC MINDSET

Pack the radio. Pick a place. Make a plan. Go operate. Learn something. Come home wanting to do it again.

Keep Learning. Keep Going Outside.

Portable operations become easier with every trip. Your first activation may take longer to set up than you expected. Your second will be faster. After a few trips, you will have a packing system, an antenna routine and a station that feels like yours.

Useful Resources

KPC Website

Kentucky Portable Club — Kentucky • Outdoors • Radio

https://kentuckyportableclub.github.io/KPC-Links/index.html

KPC Resources

Licensing, beginner resources, repeaters, POTA and Kentucky park planning

https://kentuckyportableclub.github.io/KPC-Links/resources.html

ARRL Clubs

Find an amateur-radio club and connect with local operators and mentors

https://www.arrl.org/find-a-club

ARRL Portable Operating

Portable-operation overview and ideas for getting started

https://www.arrl.org/portable-operating

POTA Documentation

Current activator and hunter guides, rules and operating references

https://docs.pota.app/

POTA Park List

Search parks and plan your next activation

https://next.pota.app/

> **A FINAL WORD**
>
> You don't need the perfect radio, the perfect antenna or the perfect park. You just need to start. Find a local ham who will show you the ropes, pack a simple station, and get outside.
>
> **Get Outside. Get On The Air.**